

Relationship Mapping + Repair

10-Week Leadership Development Program

Daily Habit	Weekly Deliverable	Reading
Draw your work relationship map. Label each: Strong / Strained / Distant.	Choose one strained relationship. Have one repair conversation — listening without defending.	Connect: Building Exceptional Relationships — Full read + Dare to Lead (Brené Brown) — Vulnerability introduction

Core Concept

Leadership is fundamentally relational. You cannot lead people you are not connected to. Yet most leaders treat relationships as a byproduct of working together rather than as something to intentionally build and maintain.

Bradford and Robin's research at Stanford found that the quality of your relationships is the single greatest predictor of both your effectiveness as a leader and your personal wellbeing. Strong relationships are built on four pillars: mutual honesty, acceptance of the whole person, understanding the other's experience, and genuine care for each other's wellbeing.

Repair matters as much as building. Every significant relationship will have ruptures — miscommunications, disappointments, perceived slights. The leaders who build the deepest trust are not those who avoid conflict, but those who repair it skillfully. Repair requires vulnerability: acknowledging your role, not defending, and listening to understand the impact.

""Connection is why we're here. It is what gives purpose and meaning to our lives.""

— Brené Brown

Framework: The Relationship Map

Draw a circle with yourself at the center. Place the people you work with on the map based on relationship quality:

— Strong: mutual trust, direct communication, genuine care

— Strained: tension, avoidance, past conflicts, or surface-level interaction only

— Distant: little connection, rarely interact, feel like strangers

For each strained relationship, ask: What happened? What is my contribution? What would repair look like?

Daily Practice

- Relationship investment: Each week, reach out to one person you've been distant from — not for a task, but to check in.
- Repair script: 'I've been thinking about how I handled [situation]. I think I could have [done differently]. I'd like to understand your experience of it. Would you be open to a conversation?'
- Vulnerability practice: In one conversation today, share something that is genuinely uncertain or difficult for you. Notice the other person's response.
- Gratitude: Tell one person specifically what you appreciate about them this week. Be concrete.

Leadership Scenarios

Scenario 1

Six months ago you missed a key deliverable that put your peer's project at risk. You've both avoided addressing it since. You pass each other in the hallway.

Reflection: What do you say? How do you initiate repair without over-apologizing or defending?

Scenario 2

A team member tells you they felt humiliated by feedback you gave them publicly three weeks ago.

Reflection: How do you respond? What does a genuine repair conversation sound like?

Weekly Reflection Prompts

Set aside 20 minutes at the end of this week to write your responses. These are for you — be honest.

Reflection 1: Who is one person in your work life whose relationship you have neglected? What has gotten in the way?

Reflection:

Reflection 2: Is there an unresolved rupture in a professional relationship? What is your contribution to it — even if the other person 'started it'?

Reflection:

Reflection 3: What does vulnerability look like in a professional context for you?
Where is your edge?

Reflection:

Weekly Habit Tracker

Day	Done?	Notes / Observations
Monday	■	
Tuesday	■	
Wednesday	■	
Thursday	■	
Friday	■	
Saturday	■	
Sunday	■	

End-of-Week Summary

Reflection: What was my biggest leadership learning this week?

Reflection: What will I carry forward into next week?

Reflection: One relationship I invested in this week: